

SMALL BUSINESS WORKBOOK

SOP Starter Kit

Templates and guides to help you document processes and build a business that runs without you.

**Capture it. Clarify it.
Hand it off with confidence.**

Includes a process inventory, priority matrix, detailed SOP template, quick SOP, testing checklist, and maintenance tracker.

If the process only lives in your head, the business still depends on you.

A useful standard operating procedure gives another capable person enough context, direction, and quality standards to complete the work without guessing.

The five-part SOP method

1

CAPTURE

Record what actually happens — not the idealized version.

2

CLARIFY

Define the outcome, owner, inputs, decisions, and standards.

3

WRITE

Turn the workflow into simple, ordered instructions.

4

TEST

Ask someone else to follow it and note every point of confusion.

5

MAINTAIN

Assign an owner and review the SOP when the process changes.

Process Inventory

List the recurring work that keeps the business moving. Start with tasks that happen often, cause delays, or depend heavily on one person.

PROCESS	AREA	FREQUENCY	CURRENT OWNER	PAIN / RISK	DOCUMENTED?

PROMPTS Client onboarding • Lead follow-up • Content publishing • Invoicing • Customer support • File management • Reporting • Hiring • Quality checks

● TEMPLATE 02

What should you document first?

Score each candidate process from 1 (low) to 3 (high). Prioritize the highest totals.

- FREQUENCY** How often does the process happen?
- BUSINESS IMPACT** How much does it affect revenue, customers, cost, or delivery?
- DEPENDENCY RISK** Would work stop if the current owner were unavailable?
- ERROR RISK** Do mistakes create rework, delays, loss, or frustration?
- DELEGATION VALUE** Would documenting it free meaningful owner or leadership time?

PROCESS	FREQ.	IMPACT	DEPEND.	ERROR	VALUE	TOTAL /15

FIRST SOP TO CREATE _____

Process Capture Worksheet

Before writing steps, capture the process in plain language. A quick screen recording or live walkthrough can help reveal details the expert performs automatically.

PROCESS NAME	<i>What is this workflow called?</i>
TRIGGER	<i>What starts the process?</i>
END RESULT	<i>What must be true when it is complete?</i>
OWNER	<i>Who is responsible for completion?</i>
INPUTS	<i>What information, files, approvals, or requests are needed?</i>
TOOLS	<i>Which systems, templates, accounts, or links are used?</i>
DECISIONS	<i>Where does the owner need judgment or approval?</i>
EXCEPTIONS	<i>What commonly goes wrong or requires escalation?</i>

Standard Operating Procedure

Use this template for recurring, multi-step, customer-facing, financial, or higher-risk processes.

SOP TITLE	Name the process clearly.
PURPOSE	Why does this process exist?
SCOPE	Where does it begin and end? What is excluded?
OWNER	Role accountable for the process.
BACKUP	Who performs it when the owner is unavailable?
FREQUENCY	Daily, weekly, monthly, event-based, or as needed.
TRIGGER	The event or condition that starts the process.
OUTPUT	The completed deliverable or final state.
TOOLS / ACCESS	Systems, folders, permissions, templates, and links.
LAST UPDATED	Date, version, and person who approved the SOP.

Procedure Steps

Write one action per row. Start each action with a verb and include the quality standard — not just the click path.

STEP	ACTION	DETAILS / STANDARD	OWNER	TOOL / LINK
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				

WRITING RULE Include screenshots only when they clarify a decision, visual standard, or interface that is difficult to describe. Keep passwords out of the SOP; reference the approved password manager instead.

Quality Control & Escalation

A process is not complete until the work is checked, documented, and handed off correctly.

Completion checklist

- ☐ The requested outcome is complete.
- ☐ Required fields, files, and records are accurate.
- ☐ Names, dates, amounts, and links were verified.
- ☐ The correct template, brand standard, or policy was followed.
- ☐ The status was updated in the system of record.
- ☐ The next person or client received the required communication.
- ☐ Exceptions, risks, or unresolved items were documented.

Escalation rules

STOP WHEN	<i>Conditions where work must pause.</i>
ASK WHEN	<i>Questions that require owner or manager input.</i>
ESCALATE TO	<i>Role and preferred communication channel.</i>
RESPONSE TIME	<i>How quickly urgent and routine issues should be raised.</i>
DOCUMENT IN	<i>Where the issue and decision should be recorded.</i>

One-Page Quick SOP

Use for straightforward, low-risk processes with fewer decisions and limited exceptions.

PROCESS	Clear process name.
OUTCOME	What does done look like?
OWNER	Role responsible.
TRIGGER	What starts the task?
TOOLS	Systems, templates, and links.

Steps

STEP	ACTION	DETAILS / STANDARD	OWNER	TOOL / LINK
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				

Done When

☐ Output checked

☐ System updated

☐ Handoff sent

☐ Exceptions documented

SOP Test & Approval Checklist

The writer should not be the only tester. Give the SOP to someone with the expected level of experience and watch where they hesitate.

TEST CRITERIA	NOTES / REVISION
☐ A person other than the process expert followed the SOP.	.
☐ The tester could identify the correct starting point and required inputs.	.
☐ Every step used clear action language and appeared in the correct order.	.
☐ All tools, links, templates, folders, and access requirements were available.	.
☐ Decision points and approval requirements were clear.	.
☐ Quality standards were specific enough to evaluate the result.	.
☐ Common exceptions and escalation paths were included.	.
☐ The final output was completed correctly without undocumented help.	.
☐ Tester questions were used to revise the SOP.	.
☐ The process owner approved the final version and review date.	.

SOP Library & Maintenance Tracker

A documented process becomes unreliable when nobody owns updates. Keep one central index and assign every SOP a review date.

SOP	AREA	OWNER	VERSION	UPDATED	NEXT REVIEW	STATUS

Suggested statuses

- DRAFT** Being written or revised.
- IN TESTING** A second person is following and validating it.
- ACTIVE** Approved and currently in use.
- NEEDS UPDATE** The process, tool, policy, or owner has changed.
- ARCHIVED** No longer used; retained only for history.

● IMPLEMENTATION PLAN

Build your first SOP system in 30 days.

Start small. A useful library of five tested SOPs is more valuable than fifty documents nobody follows.

W1**INVENTORY**

List recurring processes, score priorities, and choose the first two.

W2**CAPTURE**

Record walkthroughs, gather templates, and complete the process worksheets.

W3**WRITE & TEST**

Draft the SOPs and have another person complete each process.

W4**APPROVE & HAND OFF**

Revise, approve, train the owner, and add review dates to the library.

● MY FIRST FIVE SOPS

#	SOP
01	.
02	.
03	.
04	.
05	.

●READY WHEN YOU ARE

A business that runs without you still needs the right people behind it.

VIA VA connects growing businesses with skilled, reliable virtual assistants who can help document workflows, organize files, maintain systems, complete recurring tasks, and keep the work moving after the SOP is written.

Document the process. Delegate the work. Get your time back.

Build a Business That Runs Smarter

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